

Social, Cultural and Humanitarian Committee

(SOCHUM)

TechMUN XXXIII



Middle School General Assembly

Co-Chairs: Hiral Jain and Prajeet Mishra

Thomas Jefferson High School for Science and Technology

March 13th-14th, 2026

Dear Delegates,

We are ecstatic to invite you to the Social, Humanitarian, and Cultural Committee (SOCHUM) at TECHMUN XXXIII. We are both sophomores at TJ, and could not be more excited to be your chairs in this upcoming committee. Our weekend of debate should focus on SOCHUM's most pressing matters: Mass Incarceration and Prison Overpopulation, and Combating Human Trafficking. All of you will be assigned countries that you should represent as delegates, and throughout the committee, we hope to see that you reflect your nation's ideas and display them with your solutions.

On the topic of solutions, we are looking for innovative and realistic ideas that could be implemented with proper research. We also emphasize having a strong presence in the committee and ensuring that the debate runs smoothly. Both of us would like to see captivating and unique, mods, accompanied by collaborative unmods. However, our main focus is on upholding utmost respect for the other delegates at this conference, and that each of you is considerate of the others. Nevertheless, we encourage everyone to step out of their comfort zones, whether that means giving countless speeches or working with several other delegations in unmods. Lastly, it is important to give your best during committee and to always keep your head up. Whether this is your first conference or your fifth conference, we hope that this TECHMUN will be memorable for all of you. If you have any questions, feel free to email us at sochumtechmun2026@gmail.com.

Sincerely,

Hiral Jain and Prajeet Mishra

Topic A: Mass Incarceration and Prison Overpopulation

Introduction:

Mass incarceration is one of the world's most pressing matters, with severe overcrowding in over 100 countries driven by strict sentencing, slow judicial process, and high pre-trial detention rates. According to the Oxford Review, mass incarceration refers to the "extensive imprisonment of a large segment of the population. It is a phenomenon characterised by the rapid increase in the number of incarcerated individuals." In other words, mass incarceration is a system where prison populations are extremely high. Generally, the primary response to any form of crime is mass incarceration, which means sending large numbers of people to jail even for non-violent crimes, such as drug possession, probation violations, and minor theft.

According to the World Population Review, the nations with the largest number of people in prison are the United States, China, Brazil, India, and Russia. However, the nations with the highest incarceration rates are El Salvador, Cuba, Rwanda, and Turkmenistan, which shows that mass incarceration is not limited to population size alone, but is heavily influenced by national policy. The main issue that comes along with the incarceration of a large number of people is dehumanization, which includes psychological harm, increased violence, identity removal, human rights violations, and negative societal impacts. Furthermore, the long-term societal impacts are severe, as individuals released from dehumanizing prison environments often struggle with reintegration into society. This creates an everlasting cycle of crime and incarceration, which is the biggest issue at hand in countless nations.

Current Situation:

Mass incarceration is a problem that is on the rise all over the world. The populations in a number of these institutions, including but not limited to the Americas, Africa, and Asia, are far beyond their capacity. Recent data compiled shows that overcrowding affects well over half of the national prison systems. The United Nations has pinpointed this issue as overcrowded prisons can violate basic human rights by spreading disease, affecting mental-health, and limiting opportunities for rehabilitation. As these concerns continue to grow, governments are looking into potential reforms, but progress remains minimal.

Possible Solutions:

Several structural adjustments need to be instituted at both the national and international levels to properly address solutions to mass incarceration. At the national level, governments should begin updating their criminal codes by decriminalizing low-level, non-violent crimes, such as the possession of small amounts of drugs; moving away from mandatory minimums, and using judicial discretion proportionate to the severity of the crime committed. Furthermore, there should be limits on the length of pre-trial detention and the provision of additional government-funded legal aid to ensure that a person does not sit in jail while awaiting trial. Independent sentencing commissions should review prison populations on a periodic basis and make data-based recommendations to hinder the uncontrolled growth of prison populations. Countries should establish a system of international cooperation to combat transnational crimes using intelligence gathering rather than incarceration. Finally, countries should allocate a specific percentage of their national corrections budget to community-based rehabilitation programs, mental health agencies, and re-entry programs to provide solid incentives to reduce recidivism and reliance on incarceration.

Questions to Consider:

1. Why do some countries rely more heavily on incarceration as a response to crime rather than rehabilitation or other sentencing methods?
2. How does prison overcrowding impact the physical safety, mental health, and overall well-being of incarcerated individuals?
3. In what ways does the structure and efficiency of a nation's judicial system contribute to prison overcrowding and high pre-trial detention rates?

Helpful Links:

- 1) https://www.unodc.org/res/justice-and-prison-reform/nelsonmandelarules-GoF/UN_System_Common_Position_on_Incarceration.pdf
- 2) <https://oxford-review.com/the-oxford-review-dei-diversity-equity-and-inclusion-dictionary/mass-incarceration-definition-and-explanation/>
- 3) <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/justice-and-prison-reform/prison-reform-and-alternatives-to-imprisonment.html>

Topic B: Combatting Human Trafficking

Introduction:

Human trafficking is a large problem seen around the globe for economic gain, affecting millions of people regardless of their gender, age, or ethnicity. Trafficking is the recruitment, transportation, transfer, or harbouring of persons through force or abuse. In the modern era, as digital technology increases, trafficking has become more common and increasingly international as victims are moved efficiently across borders. Many traffickers focus their coercion on vulnerable low-income families or abandoned children who experience low parental involvement in their lives. Situations of armed conflict, political instability, and natural disasters increase vulnerability by weakening social and legal protections.

According to the UNODC's Report on Trafficking in Persons, in 2018, 46% of victims were women and 19% were girls, while 20% were men and 15% were boys. However, over the last decade, there has been a significant increase in the number of male victims as they continue to be exploited for labor. There are many forms of exploitation, such as for labor, sexual favors, entertainment, and forced marriage. Trafficked individuals are frequently forced into inhumane, violent, and unpaid conditions and compelled to perform labor in farms, factories, and construction sites. Victims can be manipulated to remove their organs and even commit crimes involuntarily. It is incredibly difficult to accurately quantify the true scale of trafficking due to its covert nature. Many cases often go unreported due to fear and limited access to authorities. This committee hopes to address the root causes that allow trafficking to occur, strengthen international cooperation, create legal infrastructure, and improve victim identification and protection strategies.

Current Situation:

Human trafficking remains an evolving global challenge, with recent UN data indicating a significant rise in forced labor and child exploitation cases since the COVID-19 pandemic.

Technological advancements have further complicated efforts to combat trafficking, as criminals use encrypted messaging apps and online platforms to recruit and exploit victims while evading detection. Even as international law enforcement amplifies and leads to thousands of arrests and rescues in transnational operations, trafficking continues to be a widespread challenge. Many cases go unreported due to fear, lack of legal protection, and limited access to authorities. There is no country left unaffected, which highlights the need for stronger legal enforcement and victim support through structured frameworks.

Possible Solutions:

It is really important to address these pressing issues with a multi-part plan. Using legal infrastructure can protect the victims and deter criminals. Additionally, assisting the survivors of human trafficking will allow them access to necessary medical, living, and legal assistance, as well as opportunities for rehabilitation. Furthermore, the use of technology can help the government raise awareness, detect crime patterns, and take additional precautions as necessary. Lastly, education and making the international community aware of the root causes of this crime, while simultaneously removing stigma in order to protect the victims, may reduce human trafficking.

Questions to Consider:

1. How can we balance the advancement of technology with safeguards to prevent its misuse in exploitation?

2. How can international collaboration be enhanced to tackle cross-border trafficking effectively?
3. In what ways can we ensure that survivors receive holistic support to prevent re-victimization?

Helpful Links:

- 1) [https://www.unodc.org/documents/middleeastandnorthafrica/human_trafficking_indicators/Handbook for Parliamentarians trafficking in persons English .pdf](https://www.unodc.org/documents/middleeastandnorthafrica/human_trafficking_indicators/Handbook_for_Parliamentarians_trafficking_in_persons_English_.pdf)
- 2) <https://www.justice.gov/humantrafficking/what-is-human-trafficking>
- 3) <https://www.un.org/en/peace-and-security/understanding-human-trafficking>



Works Cited

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